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Making the transition at the library



LIBRARY COLUMN

George Williams



George Williams Associated Press

Between the evening of April 21 and the morning of April 23, the Latah County Library District - in fact the entire VALNet library consortium - will be moving its catalog and circulation systems from our current software to a new system called Koha. The process should be fairly seamless for patrons, and we expect the only time library users will be unable to access the online catalog during that weekend is between 5 p.m. Saturday and 7 a.m. Monday. And unlike our last software change in 2006, library users will not have to get a new library card. This change should be relatively painless for library users.

So, why are we switching to Koha? There are actually several good reasons.

The most important reason is because we believe the new catalog will be easier for patrons to use. Once we're using Koha, you should find the new catalog is easy to search, it is easy to place requests, and if you want to find out what you have checked out, it's really easy to do that, too. The new system will even tell you if you have a fine, how much you owe and what the fine is for. The new system was designed for public library users, and it gives patrons easy access to their accounts as well as more control over them. There is so much good stuff in the new system, I couldn't begin to explain it all here.

The second reason we're changing is because we believe the new system will be easier for staff to use. Koha has a more intuitive interface for staff that should make it easier for us to create new library cards, easier for us to track where items are in the courier system and to help patrons find items in the library.

A third reason we are switching is because of cost. In the five years I've worked for the Latah County Library District, VALNet has lost several member libraries including Weippe Elementary, Northwest Children's Home and the Clarkston

branch of Walla Walla Community College. The cost of consortium membership is always a consideration. One of the big fears among VALNet libraries after the economic downturn in 2008 was that the cost of staying in VALNet might be too expensive for some of the member libraries - especially the school libraries. One of the great advantages of Koha is that it is an "Open Source" system and the software itself is free. Rather than paying a large corporation for the privilege of using their software (which is what VALNet does now) Koha software will not cost VALNet a dime. Instead of buying the software, we will be paying a software support company to help us move our data into Koha and then maintain the software and computer server that the software will be housed on.

Finally, one reason we're very glad the switch is happening now is that our current system, managed in Spokane, is proving more and more unreliable. I won't go into the technical details of the problem, but since November, we have had several days when our old system has crashed. Most recently, we could not check books in for several days and were unable to catalog new materials for about three weeks. This has not been good for patrons, and it has not been good for staff.

So look forward to April 23 in VALNet, when we will be operating on a new system that should make life at the library easier for those who use the library and those of us who work here.

George Williams is the account services manager for the Latah County Library District.

